

A SHOCKING TRAGEDY, MURDER OF FOUR CHILDREN.

(By Telegraph.)

Between five and six o'clock last night a shocking tragedy was perpetrated at Walthamstow, William Gouldstone having drowned three of his children—Charles, aged about three years; Herbert, two years; and Frederick, aged sixteen months—and so seriously assaulting two others, twin boys, aged seven days, that one of them has since died. The death of the other was hourly expected. Gouldstone, who is a blacksmith, employed by a firm in Lower Thames Street, London, lives at No 8, Courtney Place, adjoining St. James's Street, Walthamstow. Last week his wife was confined of twins, and she had a woman in the house to nurse her. He (Gouldstone) returned from work rather earlier than usual, and the nurse noticed that he was in a very bad mood. He told her that he wanted her to leave the house while he had a chat with his wife concerning the money that was to be paid to the doctor. The woman left the house, but just before going she heard Gouldstone ask for the boy Frederick, and noticed that the lad seemed pleased at this parental recognition. Shortly afterwards she was surprised at seeing the cistern overflowing, and going to it was horrified at discovering the dead bodies of three of the children in it. At the same time she heard screams proceeding from the room where Mrs Gouldstone was recovering after her confinement. She knocked at the door, but being unable to gain admission obtained assistance, and the door was burst open. It was then found that the enraged father, after drowning his three elder children, had struck the twin babes at their mother's breast with a hammer. The police were sent for, and Gouldstone was taken to Lea Bridge Police Station. When the nurse asked the prisoner what he had done, he replied, "Never mind, I am happy now, and she is a single woman." No motive can be assigned for the crime, except that indicated by his complaints that his wife had too many children, and since her confinement last week he had not spoken to her. He was a most abstemious man, his wife stating that she had never but once seen him the worse for drink, and his ordinary good character is shown by his having been in his present situation five or six years. The fourth child died at a late hour last night, and the other twin was not expected to live.